Family Emergency Call Plan

The voice is not proof. The callback is.

A printable kit to set up a family safe word, practise a pause line, build a callback list and agree a money rule, before an "emergency" call ever comes.

- ✓ Safe-word setup worksheet
- ✓ Pause and callback scripts
- ✓ Fillable callback list
- ✓ Phone-side card + 4 wallet cards
- ✓ 10-minute family meeting script
- ✓ 4 practice drills
- ✓ "If we already paid" first-hour checklist

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Start here

Why a plan beats a good ear

Family-emergency scams follow one script: someone you love is hurt, arrested or stranded, they need money now, and please don't tell anyone. Often a second voice, a "lawyer" or "officer", takes over to arrange payment.

What the official guidance says

FBI (IC3 PSA I-120324-PSA, Dec 3, 2024): "Create a secret word or phrase with your family to verify their identity" and verify a caller "by hanging up the phone ... and call the phone number directly."
FTC: "don't trust the voice on the line — even if it sounds like your family member or friend."
FCC: scammers may "spoof" caller ID so a call looks like it comes from a trusted source.

Is it really AI? Sometimes the FBI says criminals use AI-generated audio to impersonate relatives. Other times it's a muffled, crying voice and panic fills in the rest. You can't reliably tell under pressure, and you don't need to. This plan works either way.

How to use this kit (about 30 minutes, once)

- Page 3: pick your safe word together, in person.
- Page 4: practise the pause line out loud until it's automatic.
- Page 5: fill in the callback list and print a copy for every older relative.
- Page 6: agree the money rule and sign it.
- Page 7: cut out the phone-side card and wallet cards.
- Page 8: run the 10-minute family meeting. Page 9: practise a drill. Page 10: keep it in case money was already sent.

Move 1: Choose a family safe word

Agree on it in person, never in a group chat or email

- Use two unrelated, ordinary words (example only, don't use it: "copper lantern"). It should be easy to say under stress and hard to guess.
- Never use anything that appears online or that a stranger could look up: pets, streets, schools, teams, birthdays, nicknames.
- Everyone who might call for help, or be called, needs to know it: grandparents, parents, teens, and a trusted neighbour if they help out.
- The real person must SAY the word. Never prompt it or give a hint ("is it something about a lantern?").
- Change it if it's ever shared outside the family, a phone is lost or stolen, or someone's email is hacked. Set a reminder to review it every 6 months.

Worksheet (fill in on paper; do NOT type the word into this PDF if you'll store it

Family members who know the word:

Date agreed: _____ Next review date (6 months): _____

Where the printed copy is kept (e.g. sealed envelope in the kitchen drawer):

_____

Optional backup question: if an older relative may forget the word under stress, also agree one question whose answer isn't anywhere online ("What did we eat after the power cut?"). The FTC suggests asking a question only the real person would know.